



threshold for them to enter the art market," says Dinesh Vazirani, CEO and Co-Founder of Saffronart.

Of course, the market continues to be dominated by the Modern masters. In fact, as per one estimate 60 per cent of the market comprises artworks only by MF Husain, FN Souza and SH Raza while the balance 40 per cent is everyone else. "We are seeing a growing demand for other Modernists and this will only increase as collectors realise that there is a significant price difference in their works," says Anand.

Udit Jain of Delhi-based Dhoomimal Gallery, believes that gallerists these days are also trying to promote Modern artists beyond just the progressive group. "There are several forgotten masters such as B C Sanyal, K S Kulkarni, etc., who are now being given their due by modern galleries," he says. Jain feels that a category that collectors should look at are the contemporary artists of the mid-1990's to mid-2000's era who are now almost in the Modern category such as Atul Dodiya, Chittrovanu Mazumdar, GR Iranna, Jitish Kallat, etc. Prices of their works had fallen significantly during the financial crash of 2007-08 but have been on an upswing since.

Auction houses such as Saffronart and AstaGuru, have also made buying art easier, making it more democratic with collectors now coming not just from metros but also tier-2 towns such as Ahmedabad, Amritsar, Vadodara etc.

"The role of technology in the last 25 years has democratised art. The fact that you can be anywhere in the country and bid for a piece of art you like has made it more accessible," says Vazirani.

He believes social media has also played a big role in democratising art. "It has really helped galleries, dealers and auction houses market their works. You can even interact with artists directly and learn more about their work. It's a big enabler."

If you are a first-time collector, Vazirani advises patience. "Don't be in a hurry. Understand the history of the artist and why a painting is good or important. Art is like a reflection of the culture, society, polity around the artist at that time—it's almost a documentation of history. So, understanding that history, figuring out what appeals to you aesthetically and what balances the investment side is very important. Look, learn and be patient," he says. Sage advice indeed for a market that is ready to rise to the occasion.